

Meet the developer group trying to break the mental health stigma in tech, where moving fast &

[Rosalie Chan](#) Jan 12, 2020, 2:50 PM UTC



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- In 2013, developer Ed Finkler founded Open Sourcing Mental Illness (OSMI), an organization that promotes mental health through online resources, handbooks, research, and tech conferences.
- OSMI data suggests that developers face higher rates of health issues than the general population.
- The group attributes this to how developers often find themselves working long hours with little sleep, leading to stress and a heightened possibility of burnout.
- Volunteers at OSMI hope to break down the stigma around mental health, encourage people to reach out for help, and create a more supportive environment at tech companies by providing free resources that anyone can use.
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There's a toll that can come with the "move fast and break things" mentality of Silicon Valley. While developers may work long hours at night to hack the next big thing into existence, that also comes with the risk of long-term effects to their health and burnout.

That's why developer Ed Finkler wants to raise awareness about mental health issues to the tech community and encourage people to seek help. He started the organization Open Sourcing Mental Illness in 2013 after he gave a talk at a conference for [PHP](#), a programming language that has been used for building websites like Facebook and Yahoo.

Rather than speaking on a technical topic, as was usual at the conference, Finkler opened up about mental health issues he's dealt with since middle school, including depression, anxiety, and more.

After his talk, many people reached out to him, and Finkler realized he could do something more.

"I felt like I struck a nerve, hit something that was important about," Finkler told Business Insider. "I thought about what I could do about that...Eventually what I sort of settled on is, hey, I'll do more talks. I like doing technical talks, but what if I did a talk about mental health?"

Since then, he's gone on to do 10 to 15 talks a year about mental health. OSMI was initially funded via Indiegogo campaigns, but it's now a registered non-profit powered by donations and a team of volunteers. Its members create resources like online forums and handbooks, conduct research, and speak at tech conferences, including the prominent [KubeCon](#).

It also performs an annual survey of the IT industry to gather information on mental health issues in the developer community. The survey's findings are released under a Creative Commons license.

allows anyone to reuse that content in their own conference presentations, and research. The idea is to make it access

"It's in the tradition of collaborative learning and sharing culture. We would talk openly about those kinds of issues." "There's something natural to that."

'There's nowhere to go for support'

OSMI's research suggests that people working in the tech experience mental health issues at a much higher rate than the general population. According to [OSMI data](#), 51% of tech professionals have been diagnosed with a mental health condition. By comparison, only 15% of U.S. adults [experience mental illness](#), according to the National Alliance on Mental Illness.

Stigma around mental health issues certainly isn't limited to the tech industry, Jen Akullian, psychologist and OSMI advisory board member, told Business Insider. But there are factors within the tech industry that might exacerbate the problem.

"There are still those who believe that people who struggle with mental health are lazy and incapable and dangerous and should be punished, or it's their fault," Akullian said. "We know from research that it leads to people not reaching out for help. It's more so for people in tech. There's a higher level of expectation that they should function really highly."

Some of that comes from the still-pervasive idea of "move fast and break things," the motto once championed by Facebook.

"Tech seems to attract high-functioning motivated people with high expectations of themselves," Akullian said. "When you're in an industry that expects a lot from you and an industry that's highly innovative, it means that for innovation to happen, there's a lot of failure, and a lot of things have to break."



Psychologist and OSMI advisory board member Jen Akullian speaks at CMX Summit

'They don't know where to go'

Akullian says that tech workers are often put in high-stress environments where they don't have the opportunity to sleep, work regularly, or go on vacation. Tech workers often find themselves isolated and spend a fair chunk of their day working alone, or working from home or other remote locations. And many startups, especially small ones, don't have an HR department to offer support or help when things go wrong.

"A lot of them find themselves in companies where this is not a priority," Akullian said. "There's nowhere to go for support, and they tend to keep it to themselves, and they don't reach out for help. They don't know where to go. It seems like a pervasive problem."

The problem is serious enough that it can end careers, she says.

"Sometimes it leads to burnout," Akullian said. "Sometimes people are quitting their jobs or quitting their careers or being unhappy and not feeling the best they can and being the professional that they can."

Exacerbating the issue, she believes, is the way that some companies focus so much on the outcome that they ignore the cost of building their businesses.

"There's a lot of real problems there," Finkler said. "There's a tendency for plugging in people and looking at people as skills as opposed to a whole human being. That tendency to treat people as resources, I think, is really problematic and not good for employees and it's not good for employers."

'Companies are starting to get it'

Akullian says that if there's any good news here, it's that the industry is slowly but surely coming around to understand the problem — and take steps to address it, by working and undertaking other mental health support initiatives.

"Companies are starting to get it," Akullian said. "If they want employees to be most productive, most effective, most successful, they need to address an area that needs to be supported and at least a conversation. They need to feel comfortable approaching it and asking for help."

OSMI's programs are so in-demand in the industry, Akullian says that tech event organizers look for ways to help fight the stigma around mental health issues and encourage attendees to get what they need, and employers look for ways to offer their own instead of support.

"As tech events are realizing how mental health is impacting their audience and professionals in the field, they're showing interest in bringing the conversation into their events," Akullian said.

The goal is that by opening the platform everywhere, people can start conversations in places where they're most needed.

"That's what OSMI is trying to do, break down the stigma around mental health. When people start talking about it, we can refer our colleagues to someone, ask HR to put something in place for support, or at least, encourage people to reach out when they need help."

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